# Stage 1: Research Question


## Team: Bala Subramanian, Vagdevi Reddy, Phanindra

## Villages: Brahmaur, Chitrari and Maingal of Chamba District

### Research Question

How did changing patterns of occupation and economic interdependence shape caste/religious relations in Brahmaur, Chitrari and Maingal of Chamba district from the late nineteenth century to 1961?

This project examines economic organisation and social relations in Brahmaur, Chitrari and Maingal. The 1931 Census is particularly relevant for its information on occupation, means of livelihood, and caste and tribe categories. We will examine how different communities were positioned within agriculture, pastoralism, crafts and services, and how these occupations shaped relationships of dependence and exchange across the three villages from the colonial period to 1961.

The project draws on Marxist and Annales approaches. The Marxist perspective helps examine labour, economic dependence and social hierarchy, while the Annales approach allows us to study these relationships over the long term, including geography, pastoralism, migration and everyday village life. The sources will also be treated critically, since colonial census and ethnographic categories were not neutral descriptions of social identity.

### Primary Sources

1881 Census; 1931 Census; H. A. Rose (1910); 1961 Census Village Surveys.

### Computational Approach

**Python and regular expressions** will be used to extract text from the digitised sources and clean recurring OCR errors. **OpenRefine** will help standardise variant spellings of village names, caste/community labels and occupations while preserving their original forms. Using **Python/Pandas**, we will construct a structured dataset recording village, period, community/caste, occupation, livelihood and economic relationships, with source and page references retained for verification. We will use **Pandas and Matplotlib** for tabulation, frequency analysis and visualisation of patterns across villages and periods. For the 1961 village surveys, **Voyant Tools** and, where useful, **TF-IDF in Python** will be used to identify distinctive vocabulary and recurring themes. Computational analysis will identify patterns for further historical interpretation rather than replace close reading of the sources. For the **1961 village surveys**, NLP methods will support qualitative analysis. **Named Entity Recognition (NER), Bag-of-Words, word frequencies and TF-IDF** will help identify important people, places, communities, occupations, objects and recurring vocabulary.